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suspended for six months the entry into the US of all foreign students seeking to study in Harvard due to "security concerns". Harvard has vowed to "protect its international students". Previously, Secretary of State Marco Rubio ordered a global pause on all new student visa interviews.

Harvard is now engaged in two legal battles with the US government: one over research funding and the other over its ability to host international students. It has taken a firm public stance in defence of academic freedom, in contrast to Columbia University, which has almost fully complied with federal demands. Even so, the administration has stated that Columbia failed to meet accreditation criteria due to inadequate protection of Jewish students.

The situation casts a shadow on the future of Indian students aspiring to study in the US—especially at Harvard and other targeted institutions. Even if courts continue to favour Harvard, uncertainty may force students to rethink their plans. The tension also resonates with India's own challenges. Incidents at JNU, TISS and Ashoka raise similar questions about the interplay between academic freedom and state control.

Amidst the chaos, one thing is certain—academic freedom is struggling, with potential consequences for intellectual inquiry, the global perception of US higher education, and America's bilateral relations with countries like India and China, which are the source of the largest contingents of foreign students. It also risks tarnishing the soft power of the US.

Notably, Harvard, which, in fact, is older than the US itself, is in a rare position to resist. The Harvard Corporation, with its over $50 billion endowment, has allocated $250 million to address funding cuts. Most institutions in the US and around the world lack such resources or autonomy. Others will learn from this moment, but not all the lessons will be in the public interest.

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notes. "Yet, with sophisticated AI tools parsing global chatter, delays are unlikely to be drastic."

ALTERNATIVES TO AMERICA

In the long run, the Trump administration's visa clampdown threatens not just foreign students, but also the economic lifeblood of higher education in the US and its innovative edge. Many universities, especially those outside the Ivy League, depend on full-paying foreign students to subsidise domestic education. A drop in enrolment would plug this crucial revenue stream. Indian students are already exploring backup plans. They are considering deferring admissions, or looking at alternative countries. Bengaluru-based Nishant (*name changed*), who will complete his BTech in electronics engineering next May, is among those reconsidering their choices. "People who have already finished their master's [in the US] still haven't found jobs," he says. "Is it worth it then to spend so much in the US when places like Germany offer more subsidised tuition?"

While national security is a legitimate concern for any country, America's xenophobic turn could erode its academic pre-eminence

Enrolment patterns of Indian students reflect the shift. Between 2023 and 2024, Germany saw a 49 per cent rise in Indian students, from 23,296 to 34,702, as per a response by Union minister of state of education Sukanta Majumdar in Parliament. Kalpesh Banker of EduShine Search Partners, an education strategy consulting firm, lists the advantages of other destinations. "Canada has friendly visa policies and post-study work permits, Australia and the UK offer strong research and shorter courses. Germany, Hong Kong, Singapore and the UAE, too, are rising education hubs, with low fees, cultural diversity and robust facilities."

Meanwhile, the Trump administration's crackdown on international students signals more than just bureaucratic tinkering; it portends a potential reordering of America's relationship with global talent. Cloaked in the garb of national security, a legitimate concern for any country, these policies are sowing confusion and fear, eroding the very advantages that have underpinned American academic and innovative pre-eminence. A recalibration is indeed in order: one balancing security with openness and reaffirming the value of international students. Else the US could squander its role as a magnet for the world's brightest. ■

—with Ajay Sukumaran